



## BEFORE

Confederate secretary of the Navy, Stephen Mallory, believed that raids on U.S. maritime commerce might hurt Northern business interests, deprive the North of war material, and weaken the blockade.

### THE PRIVATEERING TRADITION

**Privateering** was a time-honored if not-quite-honorable practice in use since at least the 16th century. With a **Letter of Marque and Reprisal** issued by a belligerent government, a privately owned ship could **raid enemy commercial shipping**. Captured ships became prizes, subject to adjudication by a recognized court.

In 1861, the Confederate government issued Letters of Marque to privateers daring enough to elude the **Federal blockade** (see [Blockading the South](#)). Most neutral nations, however, refused to allow prizes to be brought into their ports. The Lincoln administration, moreover, **did not recognize the Confederacy as a legitimate nation** and threatened to **hang its privateers as pirates**. Those willing to run the risk soon discovered that more money was to be made in **blockade-running**, than in privateering.

### COMMERCE RAIDERS

Confederate navy secretary Mallory had little confidence in privateers. The alternative was to entrust the task to fast naval **ships**. With no cruisers, Mallory **converted steamships**, like CSS *Sumter*, and **sent agents abroad to procure**, clandestinely, well-designed and **well-armed commerce raiders**.

When, in June 1861, Captain Raphael Semmes and CSS *Sumter* left the Mississippi River for the Gulf of Mexico, outrunning the ships of the Union blockade, he was following Stephen Mallory's instructions to "do the enemy's commerce the greatest injury in the shortest time."

Across the Atlantic in England, James D. Bulloch, a Confederate agent, had a similar brief: "Get cruising ships afloat," Mallory had told him, "with the quickest possible dispatch." While Semmes made his name in the *Sumter*, Bulloch managed to circumvent both British neutrality laws and U.S. diplomatic protests to procure 18 ships. Eleven became blockade-runners, seven commerce raiders. Three ships became legends.